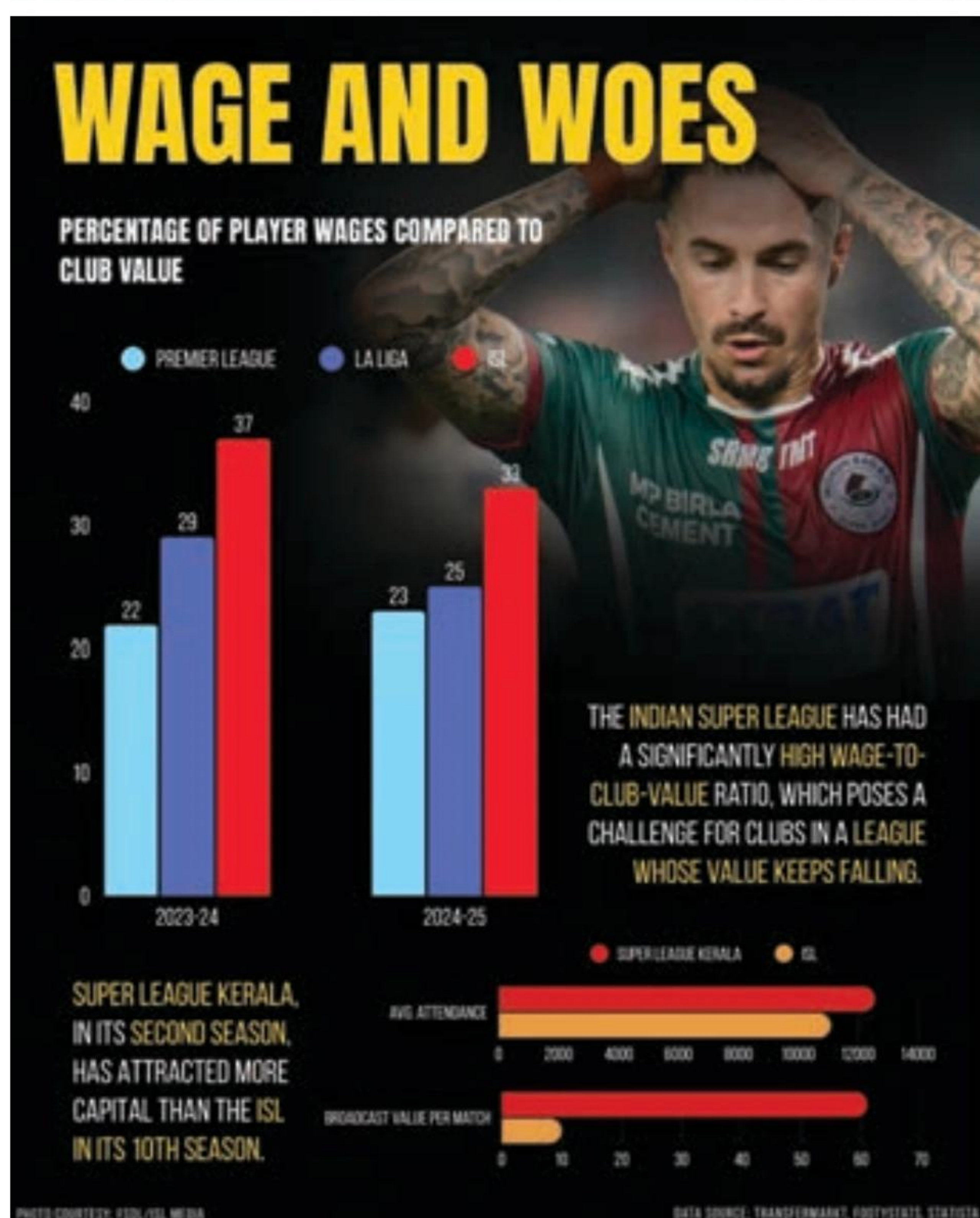
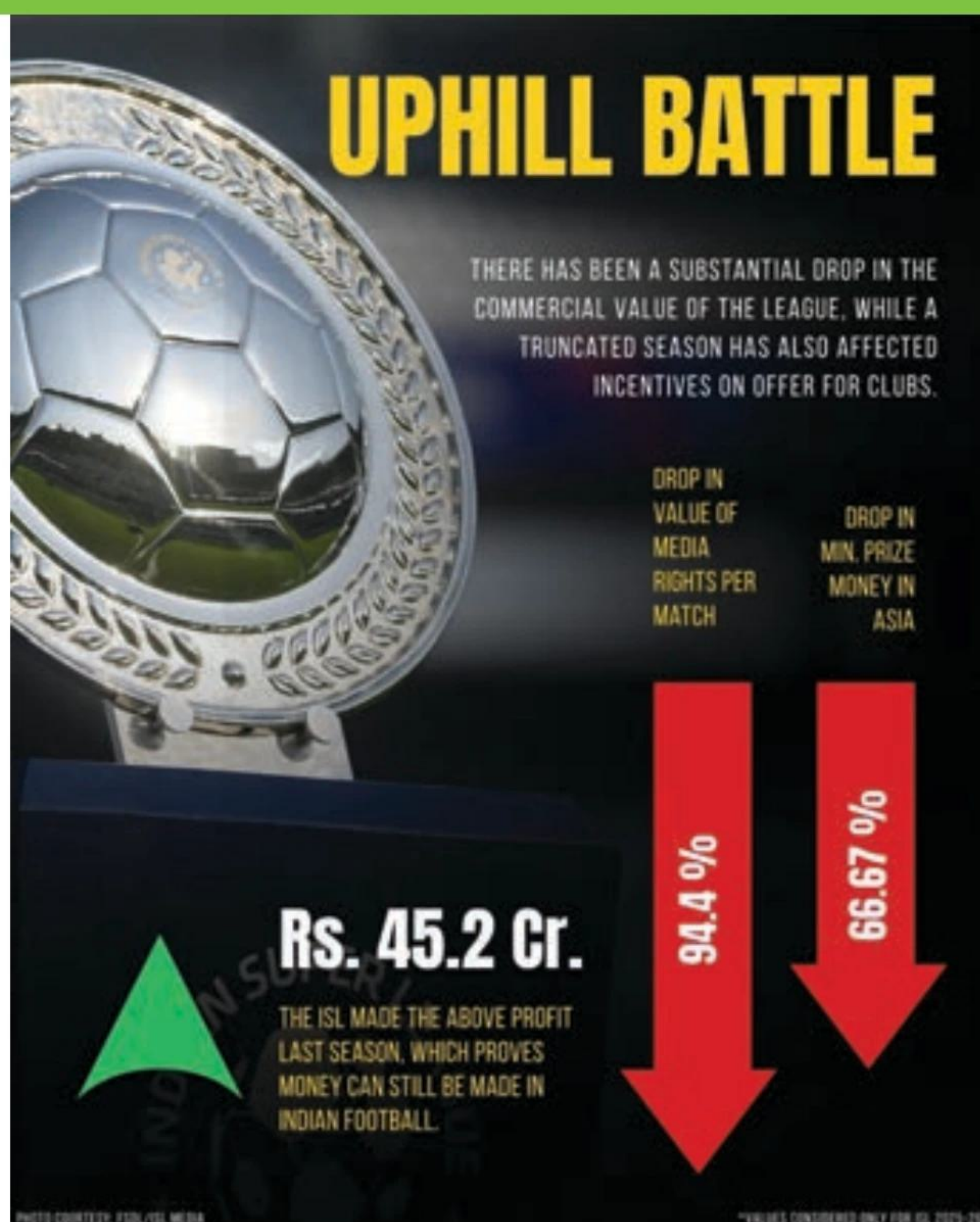




league with a depreciating value. In the 2023-24 season alone, 37 per cent of the clubs' combined valuation went into salaries, as per Transfermarkt and FootyStats. That fell marginally to 33 per cent last season.

It still ranked significantly higher than elite leagues like La Liga and the Premier League, where that share was 25 per cent and 23 per cent, respectively.

The stakes and the incentives will both be scarce this season.

The truncated format will not have playoffs, which, under the existing prize-money format, would wipe out the prize pool set aside until last season.

Unless the federation and the ISL Interim Committee come up with an alternative plan, the prize pool could shrink from Rs. 15.5 crore (ISL Cup winner: 6 Cr., Runner-up: 3 Cr., 3rd/4th: 1.5 Cr. each, ISL Shield winner: 3.5 Cr.) in the previous season to Rs. 5 crore (ISL Shield winner: 3.5 Cr., Runner-up: 1.5 Cr.). Even accounting for a smaller campaign, that is a fall of approximately 67.7 per cent.

At the continental level, India previously had one confirmed spot for the ISL Shield champion and an optional slot for the Super Cup champion in the AFC Champions League 2.

With ISL teams not meeting the minimum-match criteria (each club must play at least 24 matches in a season), India's confirmed spot was converted into another optional spot.

That will impact the minimum club earnings for the ISL champion. It used to get at least USD 300,000 (approx. Rs. 2.7 crore) for the direct spot, but will now get only one-third of it: USD 100,000 (approx. Rs. 90 lakh).

For example, Bagan, last season's ISL Cup and Shield winner, won Rs. 12.2 (6+3.5+2.7) crore in prize money. In contrast, the league winner, according to last season's breakdown, will get a minimum of Rs. 4.4 (3.5+0.9) crore in this campaign.

It is, therefore, little surprise that the clubs have requested subsidised "access to sporting infrastructure" for three years and "temporary rationalisation of club licensing requirements for the current season".

The silver lining

The night is darkest before dawn.

The federation, owning the ISL for the first time, could draw solace from the fact that last season saw FSDL post a net profit of Rs. 45.2 crore from the league. There is money that can be made in Indian football.

There is also growing optimism among